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Peter Appleyard

Peter Appleyard is one of the most respected of all Canadian musicians, and has been performing on vibes and drums from his home base of Toronto since the 1950s. He was born in Grimsby, England, on August 26, 1928. His long career has included associations with Benny Goodman, Bucky Pizzarelli, Dick Hyman, and Frank Sinatra.

Peter was interviewed in Utica, NY, on October 4, 2012, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm here at the Hotel Utica with vibist Peter Appleyard. Welcome to Utica.

PA: Thanks, Monk. Before we go any further, how did you get the name Monk?

MR: Aha! You've turned the tables on me. Actually it was because of a big, long, blue coat I used to wear, with a hood on it.

PA: Oh yeah.

MR: And someone said, "You look like a Monk with that thing on." And it stuck.

PA: That's similar to the moniker that Zoot Sims adopted.

MR: How did he get that, do you know?

PA: Well I think he was playing in this school band and they had the music stands, they were old music stands, and they had the names of the guys on the music stands. And they were either their real name or a pseudonym or whatever. And his said, "Zoot." It stayed with him.

MR: Great. Well I'm glad to have you here for this concert at Hamilton College. And I've been thinking of some things I wanted to ask you about. You're from England.

PA: Yes. I was born in a place called Grimsby, on the east coast of England. It was the largest commercial fishing port in England. And I was born there on a Tuesday and I didn't like it. They moved me on a Wednesday down to a place called Cleethorpes, which is a place adjacent to it, a seaside resort.

MR: No kidding.

PA: And I lived there until I was, until I first went on the road. I think when I was 16, 17.

MR: And you were a teenager during World War II?

PA: Yes I was. Yeah.

MR: What do you remember about that time?

PA: I remember that I slept in an air raid shelter for three consecutive years. The first year I was evacuated to Wales because we were vulnerable, being a port. And they brought me

back — nothing much happened for the first year — so they brought me back and it started, to a certain extent. I remember once seeing a flying bomb coming, you know?

MR: The V1, the V2s?

PA: No. They came too fast. This was a buzz bomb they called them. It was like a small jet plane. Something like the drones that you see today. And then they — Hitler had decided that he couldn't demoralize the Londoners with these bombings, so he moved up to the provinces. And ours was one town where they experimented with a new anti-personnel bomb, called the butterfly bomb. And they would drop it, and it was about the size of a hand grenade. And it was a potent as a hand grenade. But when it fell it triggered a hairspring. It didn't explode. But if you walked with six feet of it, it would blow up. I left school when I was 13, public school, and in those days in Britain you had to pay for a child's secondary education, high school. But my parents were victims of the recession and didn't have much money. They couldn't afford to do that. And so they applied me for an apprenticeship for a compass adjuster and nautical instrument-maker.

MR: A compass adjuster?

PA: Yeah. We would take a ship out into the River Humber, which was about three miles wide, and we'd take a bearing, and say that was true north, and in those days the compass was not magnetic, they worked with magnets, and adjust accordingly the magnets and what have you, to bring it truthfully into line, true north. I was doing that for about two years, and on one occasion I had to go and pick up some Admiralty Charts — not music charts — regular Admiralty Charts for the British Navy. They used to have corvettes and this type of vessel, to circumvent the British minefields, to get out into the North Sea. Well this 30-minute errand used to be an hour's adventure for me, because on the way to the Admiralty there's a record shop. And I always used to stop in there and audition some records, which you could do in those days. You could take three or four records and go and listen to them and come back and say, "I'd like to have this one" you know, so-and-so. So this day, here I am in this record shop listening to probably a Benny Goodman Sextet record, and I was tapping away with some drum sticks. Meantime the Royal Navy is waiting to go to sea, and the Admiral is saying, "Where the hell are those charts, we're losing the tide." And anyway this door opens and this fellow with a big moustache, and it was an ex-RAF type as a matter of fact, and he says, "Say, old chap, do you play the drums?" I said, "Yeah." "Well," he said, "our drummer got caught in bed with another woman last night by his wife, and she promptly took the fire axe off the wall and chopped up his drums." I say he was pretty lucky. "And if you'd like to come down to the Palace Theater on Saturday morning and audition for 'Felix Mendelssohn's Hawaiian Serenaders,'" (it was an Alvino Rey type band, you know) "come down." So I went down

adjuster's apprentice I was earning 7 schillings and 6 pence a week, which in those days was like, oh maybe, it was like one dollar. Mr. Mendelsohn offered me 17 pounds a week. So guess what I did? It was rather a difficult decision because I was in love with a beautiful girl and it meant leaving her, and I thought oh, shall I do this? And then it occurred to me, I thought about it and I spoke to my parents of course, and they said, "Well you should try it and see how it works." Those were the days when vaudeville theatres had big bands as their attraction. Ours was the number one band in Britain. We were the first band on British television. We broadcast from the Crystal Palace, which is not there anymore. We made a film for Pathe, and we traveled all around the country. I did that for about six months and then I was conscripted into the Royal Air Force.

MR: Did you have band experience before you went with them?

PA: Yes. I studied with a drummer who used to let me sit next to him when he was playing with an Artie Shaw type big band. So this was great, great, a great opportunity for me. And occasionally he would take off himself. Eventually he retired I think, and I got the job. Prior to that I was working in a cinema with a little band, prior to the movies, and the drummer, starting home one night, saw one of these butterfly bombs. He walked up to it and it killed him.

MR: No kidding.

PA: Yeah.

MR: I was going to ask about that, if you knew anybody that had encountered them.

PA: One night they dropped three thousand of these things on our town. And incendiary bombs as well. And that was basically the bulk of the bombing. I guess as we started to move into Germany and, with the second world war, the invasion.

MR: What do you remember about VE day?

PA: I remember dancing on the street. Yeah. Everyone was kissing everybody and we were all dancing. And oh it was crazy. I remember the day that they invaded too, with the invasion. I was on the dock still, of working as apprentice compass adjuster. That was '45.

MR: 1945. Yeah. And what was your job in the service?

PA: Well once they found out I was a musician they sent me home to get my drums, which was great, because I wanted to see that lovely girl. And I had a weekend's leave and brought it back. And it was a military band. And when it came time for me to be demobilized — I had to do 18 months — everyone, it was mandatory. Because we still were under the War Measures Act. We were having all that trouble with the Russians with Berlin, you remember the support we gave all the Berliners. The warrant officer, who was a real bad one, said to me, "Oh," he said, "so Appleyard, you're being

said, “I’ll make you a sergeant.” I said, “Oh I don’t think so.” He said, “There’s going to be another war and I can’t guarantee you’ll get back in the band.” I said, “I’ll take my chances.” So I’m leaving and he said, “Oh by the way, Appleyard, you’ll never make it in music.” So anyway about 15 years ago, the wing commander in charge of all the bands of the Royal Air Force, came over to Toronto to play a concert in the big band shell. And guess who was the other band? Me.

MR: Nice story.

PA: So anyway he was one of those stubby kind of guys, he was a wing commander, and he had to share my dressing room you see? “Oh,” he says, “Old chap, you were in the Air Force, were you?” I said, “Yes.” He said, “What rank were you?” I said, “I was a leading aircraftsman.” And I said, “I was attached to the number 1 radio-controlled fighter command band, eleven group.” “Oh Jolly Old Wheeler, good chap.” I said, “Yeah, when you see him tell him I’m still struggling to make it.”

MR: That’s a good one.

PA: “By the way, move that stuff off my dressing room table.”

MR: Yeah. You know you don’t have a very distinctive English accent.

PA: I don’t?

MR: To my ears anyway.

PA: You know it’s funny that you say this because where I come from their dialect or whatever you could call it, accent, is very broad. Like for instance if I’d grown up around there I’m sure I would have adopted it. I go back and I can hear my accent slipping into that way of speaking. And it’s funny you know, about four years ago I went back and I invited my four cousins to come to see me play. They’d never seen me play. And so one of them, Brian, said, to me, “Peter, what happened to your accent? You don’t talk like us anymore. You’re talking posh now.” I said, “Brian, I’ve been gone for 50, 60 years, living with Canadian people, married to a Canadian girl, and consequently I haven’t deliberately tried to lose my accent.” “Ah, well, I can’t understand what you’re saying anymore.”

MR: He said you were talking what?

PA: Posh. Well you know in Britain it’s like in the line of “My Fair Lady” they were singing and the Professor, Higgins, says you can always identify an Englishman the minute he opens his mouth, you can immediately identify him. It’s like, and it still is to a certain extent, a class distinction there. You know if you go to a proper school, I would say old chap. It would be actual boy and jolly good show, you know this kind of an accent, a southern or sophisticated accent, which comes probably with the schools and the exposure that these people get. And maybe that type of an Englishman, like ultra-rich or

whatever, has this accent. And it immediately identifies him, that he went to a good college, and so consequently in comes this little bit of prejudice you know.

MR: So parch? I'm not sure what the word was that you used. You're speaking —

PA: Posh. P-O-S-H.

MR: Oh posh.

PA: It's like some rich, posh person.

MR: I understand now. Okay. Posh.

PA: And anyway I've survived it. I go back, and they can still understand me.

MR: Okay. Well I wanted to ask you, I read this little anecdote. I guess you were en route from Bermuda to Canada or something and you had a stop in New York?

PA: It was going to Bermuda, from England.

MR: And you happened to see Lionel Hampton?

PA: Yes. We flew over on BOAC and we got behind. And consequently they put us up at the Gotham Hotel, 55th and Fifth Avenue. They don't do that anymore. And I had never been to North America. All I could remember in my lifetime is rationing, you couldn't buy clothes, couldn't buy candies, you only got an ounce and a quarter of meat a week or something or other, it was pretty bad. And when I got this offer from the same chap, I say, "Oh boy, you play the bloody drums?" He wrote me this letter, because we didn't have a telephone, we couldn't get a telephone during the war. "Would you be interested in an 18-month contract in Bermuda, with the possibility of a stay over in New York?" I said, "Oh my God, yeah." So anyway we get to New York and they ushered us down into the Gotham, which was at 55th and Fifth Avenue, not bad. And we only had $25 between us, because of the currency restrictions. I think we had $5 each. In those days it was very difficult. The war had just finished and, it was finished a couple of years, it was Christmas 1949. So we walked down 55th toward Broadway, not knowing where we were going, and I see this sign, "Bop City." Doug Duke at the organ, the George Shearing Quintet, and Lionel Hampton and his Orchestra. I said, "Guys we've got to go in." They said, "We don't have the money." "Well let's see how much it is." I think it was two bucks to go in. Anyway we all went in and I heard him play that night. I had seen him on the movies before, you know. He'd been my inspiration in England. He was the only vibraphone player I was aware of, until 1946, when I was walking through a Woolworth's Store and I heard this Benny Goodman record of "Slipped Disc." And it was Red Norvo with Slam Stewart and that wonderful group. So that was it. And I went back to Bermuda and once I got enough money together I took a vacation up in New York and I bought a larger vibraphone because mine was very tiny. Actually I'll tell you this very brief story about the vibraphone and how I got attached to it. During the war I

there at the time. I remember once I went in and there was a brand new set of Slingerland drums with big cymbals. I couldn't believe it. I thought jeez, I've got to get to America, I've really got to get to America. Anyway, this night we were playing this aerodrome — and it was a very large aerodrome. And this guy came up, and I was playing drums in this accordion band, and this guy came up with a little tiny vibraphone and he starts to tap with one hand and he had a flatbed guitar and he'd put an electric motor in it with plectrums on a wheel, hitting one string going brrrrrr, and he'd slide his steel up and down there and he's play arpeggiated chords with the vibraphone. But the war was on you know. So anyway, I went up to him after and I said, "Mr. Blakey, that's quite an instrument." I said, "Now can I try it?" He said, "Yeah, sure, go ahead." So there was a cute girl standing there and she said, "You sound good on that." I thought aha, I should be playing this. Anyway, I said, "Would you sell them to me." And he said, "No I can't do that." I said, "well all right, if you ever want to sell it let me know." You know. So the war ended and a knock came at my door, Mr. Blakey. He said, "You still want to buy the vibraphone?" I said, "Yeah." He said, "15 pounds." Now I was still working as a compass adjuster's assistant. So 15 pounds was a king's ransom. I knew a guitarist who played in a big band with me and I asked him to loan me the money. I borrowed the money and I bought it. My father was furious. You didn't do that in those days, you know, don't buy anything on time. If you can't afford it don't buy it. So I bought it. About 15 years ago we went back and I went to look this man up, Mr. Blakey, he was still alive. He said, "I'm going to tell you something now I couldn't tell you before." He said, "Do you remember when we played those aerodromes, I never came home with you?" I said, "Mr. Blakey, it was 60 years ago, but now that you mention it" — because we used to go on bikes. "No, you didn't as a matter of fact." He said, "Well I'll tell you, I am telling you now, I was a British spy. And the vibraphone was a cover for me to get on the aerodrome without being suspected by a possible German spy or sympathizers in Germany, on the airport." I mean you couldn't say anything to him, there were signs everywhere, it would "be like dad, keep mum."

MR: Be like dad, keep mum.

PA: Yeah. And I said, "What did you do." Well he said, "After the concert they put me in a single engine aircraft with a pilot and fly me behind the German lines in France," he says, "just prior to the audition — invasion rather." And they'd shut the engine off about a mile before a predetermined field, and the Maquis would guide us down with flashlights, and we'd glide in and I'd exchange information with the Maquis, the French resistance, pertaining to what I'd seen, what are the Germans doing" blah blah blah blah blah. I said, "Mr. Blakey, how many times did you do that?" "Well" he said, "at least twelve times."

MR: And the vibes were his cover, huh?

PA: Yeah.

MR: That's really a great story. And what was the French resistance? It was called the Maquis.

PA: Maquis.

MR: Maquis. Wow. That's really neat. That's a really great story. How big were the vibes? Like two octaves?

PA: Two octaves. Yes.

MR: And you would ride your bike home from the gig?

PA: And my father made a trailer, a wooden trailer for me, to put the drums in. And then when I bought the vibes, now we used to have — we used to deliver groceries and they had a basket, and they had a little box on the front. And I started out playing waltzes on them, with the big band. Then eventually I moved to a smaller band and I started to work at it.

MR: Oh I wish there was a picture of you with your bike and your drums and your vibes. Were you playing mostly by ear?

PA: Mostly?

MR: By ear? When you started doing the vibes —

PA: Well yeah. Nobody could teach me. So what I did, I was taking piano lessons, I adopted the right hand of the piano, all the exercises and what-have-you, and basically taught myself by listening to Hampton really. And then when Red came along I listened to Red. And then there was one guy that played, Art Van Damme. He was a good player. I started to get a few of his records, and I think there was a group called the Merry Mac Singers, they had a vibraphone player. It wasn't very popular. It wasn't heard that much. And it's like today is. It's almost becoming an endangered species, which is unfortunate.

MR: Were records back then a precious commodity? I mean were they precious?

PA: Yeah they were. And they were expensive for a guy like me. The first record I bought was "In the Mood" because it was Glenn Miller which was on whatever it was on, Columbia or RCA, and I couldn't afford that. I had to buy the English version of it by a band called Joe Walsh, which was a shilling cheaper [scats]. But yeah, I forget how much they cost but if you bought the record you couldn't take the girl to the movies you know.

MR: You had to have your priorities in order I guess. And they were 78s right?

PA: Yeah.

MR: So why Canada?

PA: Why?

MR: Why.

PA: Well actually it was a girl I guess originally, that sort of got me up there. I met this girl in

country and I didn't feel I was ready for New York, you know. And whilst I was up there to visit this girl, at the Colonial Tavern, which is a very famous jazz club there, Red Norvo was playing with his trio, with Tal Farlow and Charlie Mingus. And so I met him and they invited me to go down to Rochester with them. Mingus was out of it then. He said, "Drive me down in my Cadillac." I said, "Are you kidding?" I said, "I've never driven here." "Oh you can do it, get in my Cadillac and drive." I said, "But I don't have a driving license for this place. I've got one for Bermuda." "Okay." And I said, "No, no, I'll come down on the bus." So I went down on the bus. And they played this hotel which is similar to this one, in Rochester, and it was so great to hear that trio with Red. I mean he was a genius when it came to playing. It was incredible.

MR: Red?

PA: Norvo. Yeah. Four mallets. And his sound, you know, was so beautiful. He took — they had pulsators and the resonators you know, to give it a vibrato. He removed them. He wouldn't use them. He got that flat, beautiful, crystal-like sound, yeah.

MR: That was a trio without a drummer, wasn't it?

PA: That was, yeah, that was the trio, yeah.

MR: And was it Tal Farlow or somebody, on guitar?

PA: Guitarist. And Mingus.

MR: Right.

PA: So you liked Canada and you found work?

PA: I went back, and after I finished my 18 months in Bermuda I went back home to England and I told my parents that I wanted to emigrate. I couldn't see any future in England. I was sitting in this old radio gig, in this old railway carriage, and it was so depressing and everything. And I thought eh, I think I'll give it a try. And so I went back. The thing didn't work out with the girl. And when I went to join the union, it was an ex-Brit there. And he said, "Oh, where did you come from?" I said, "Well I came from England but I was in Bermuda working." "You shouldn't have been working there." I said, "What do you mean I shouldn't?" He said, "That's American Federation of Musicians territory." I said, "Well I accepted the gig in England on Waldorf Street," I said, "I knew nothing about that, I just wanted to work." He said, "Go away and don't come back for a year, and don't play a note."

MR: Man. That's tough.

PA: So I wanted to join the union and I knew I couldn't get started. In those days if they caught you sitting in they'd fine you a whole bunch of money. It was terrible. They got rid of that particular group of union people. It was almost like the Spanish Inquisition, you know. Anyway, I got a job as an elevator operator in the biggest hotel, but I got

doors. Then I was working selling sporting goods and tobacco in a big department store. Then I went from there to a room clerk at the King Edward Hotel, which is a fancy hotel, and I stuck that out, but it was nights — 11 at night 'til 8 in the morning. I did it for about six months. But I was determined. I never even thought about going on welfare you know, like a lot of people do today, because it was a disgrace in England to go on the dole, you wouldn't do it. And then I wound up working in a shirt shop, and the guy that owned it happened to be a runner for Al Capone.

MR: Bringing booze over the border?

PA: Yeah. Milt Hinton used to do that.

MR: I heard that.

PA: He was a driver, or an assistant. Anyway, I got into this nice clothing store and about the time, after about three or four weeks, I got my union card, and I got a gig in a bar. And I had to do a Saturday matinee you see? Oh, how the hell am I going to get away to do this matinee on a Saturday with a clothing store. So I told my manager. He said, "Peter," he said, "take your lunch from 3 to 4 and if Harry asks where you are I'll say you've gone off on an errand from 4 to 5" you see. The place wasn't very far away, I could whip into it. So I pulled this off for about three weeks, and Harry was — you know like George Raft, remember George Raft?

MR: Um hum.

PA: And he looked like a gangster, dressed so smart and he'd stand there. And if he was doing this much he was really animated you know. So I came in this Saturday and he said, "Where do you go on a Saturday afternoon?" I said, "Mr. Field, I've got to tell you, I'm a musician and I do this matinee. I've really waited a year for the union card and I would appreciate it, I'm awfully sorry, anything I can do? Some extra hours?" "What time do you finish at night?" I said, "One in the morning." Oh yeah, and you have to drive up to North Toronto, that's two o'clock by the time you get to bed, and you've got to get up at seven to get here." And then he said, "Why don't you come in executive hours? Come in at ten in the morning and take Saturday afternoons off?" I thought then he is going to say yeah, and don't do it on my time, you're fired. And then he said to me, "And if it doesn't work out, Peter, you've still got a job here."

MR: Oh that's just great.

PA: Nice, huh?

MR: Nice.

PA: I never forgot that.

MR: Yeah. You know you've had an interesting combination of running into people that were tough on you, and some people who sort of very serendipitously helped you out. Yeah.

PA: Yeah.

MR: Okay.

PA: Nobody would teach me. The only person that was playing vibes then was a man called Roy Marsh. He was working with one of these big bands. It was Eric Winstone's big band, and three or four of the guys in the band, they came to the theater to play, and three or four of them came down to hear me play at this little ballroom where I was working in the small group and playing vibes on the side. And I asked Roy Marsh if he would teach me then and he said no, he wouldn't teach me. So I had to make my own way. And I really wasn't a professional caliber until I spent every day practicing in Bermuda, all the time I was there. And I formed a trio there with a couple of the local guys, African-American kids. And we had a very nice trio and so that was a good experience. And the guy let me play the odd number in the band that I was playing for the dancing. In those days, in 1950, '51, in Bermuda, in the winter, you had to come to the ballroom to dance in a dinner jacket. And the ladies had to wear long dresses. Yeah it was very formal. But it was a good experience. I enjoyed it. It was seven nights a week for eighteen months. No night off. And on Sunday we had to do a concert. So I'd always do a vibraphone solo, you know. So that helped me develop.

MR: If someone asked you, if they came up and said, "Can you play 'These Foolish Things'" for instance, and you didn't know it but you said, I better learn that song, how did you go about it back then?

PA: I would learn the melody and then I got a fake book. Some guy on a boat, who was an American fellow, had this fake book and I bought it. It was a good fake book, just elementary changes, but it gave me the direction. And then I kept, you know I would pick up this lick and that lick. And I probably played a lot of melody more than jazz. I mean I always liked playing melody.

MR: Yeah. Melody's good.

PA: Yeah. I made a beautiful record with strings some years ago, Rick Wilkins the great arranger that used to arrange for the Boss Brass, did the arrangements for me. And it really was a nice record. And it was at the time when we would get airplay on the FM stations, so it got a lot of play.

MR: Did you happen to work with either guitar players or piano players along the way that really helped you with understanding the chord changes and all that?

PA: Yes, this fellow that loaned me the money in England, another interesting story. How's your film, have you got — are you okay?

MR: Yeah, we're good.

PA: He loaned me this 15 pounds, and whilst I was in Bermuda the bass player left. So the

guitar player that plays bass. He's a good guitar player and he's not a bad bass player." He said, "What kind of a guy is he?" Because they were always concerned about the personality of bringing somebody out all that way. I said, "Oh, I know him, he's very quiet," I said, "but he won't cause any trouble." He said, "Well all right." So anyway, out he comes. And I used to do a lot of wandering around Bermuda. And I went to the movies once and it was a movie about, I think it was a "Third Man" theme or something or other, and "Oh" he said, "he's not really like that." And he was sort of critical of it. And anyway, I left to come to Canada. And shortly afterwards I left, one night they were playing on the bandstand and these two big guys came right in and said, "Are you Lenny Stewart?" "Yes." "Follow us." Handcuffs. Took him out. He was a roaring Communist. And he was trying to build a cell in Bermuda while he was there. They had been intercepting his mail. Talk about situations, huh? Anyway I never saw him — I think he went to jail. And some years after I was playing with Peanuts Hucko in England in Sheffield, and he walked in. I didn't know what to say to him. He said, "Good to see you." I said, "Yeah, how are you?"

MR: Yeah. How's the Communism going? Gee.

PA: But during the time of the war, the Russians at the beginning were our enemies of course, as you remember. Then they came around to our side after Hitler invaded them. And all of a sudden I found myself playing in a Communist meeting one night. You know, and this drummer, who I had no idea was a Communist, he said, "You've got to play this gig for these people I'm in this group with." I said, "yeah?" We go there and there's a big Russian flag. But anyway I mean the war was — they were on our side, and we had Russian prisoners in my town, and they let them all out, and they would gather in the streets and sing, a cappella, oh it was so beautiful, some of these voices. But that was the war. But that was the story about the guy — yeah they took him right — and they didn't even let him take his clothes. He left the bass on the stand and took him out and put him on an airplane right away. Yeah. But it was great. And then of course I came back and before I left England I had a job at a place called the Isle of Wight. And all the liners would go by there, heading for New York. And I'd sit on the beach looking at these boats and think oh God, if I could only get on one of those, as a gig, you know, so I could go to New York. And here I am all of a sudden, a job in Bermuda with a stop off in New York which was great. Then, after I got my union card I left the shop selling ties and shirts, and I got a job in the Colonial Tavern where I saw Red. It was two levels. We were on the bottom level, and the big shots were on the second level. Everyone came. Duke — oh gosh, every major star — Tatum, Billie Holiday, the Basie band, the Hampton band, and I got to know them all. Because in their break they'd come downstairs and have a taste and

we would do is to have a weenie roast or whatever, spaghetti night, and invite them all over. So the room was filled with Ray Nance, Clark Terry, Duke Ellington, and I mean Duke, I knew him intimately as I know you basically now. The last time I saw him I was with Benny at the Rainbow Grill at Rockefeller Center, and I went to the Stage Delicatessen and Harry Carney, the baritone player, was sitting there: "Hey Peter, how are you." I said, "Harry, how are you?" He said, "What are you doing working here?" I said, "Yeah I'm with Goodman." He said, "Oh great." I said, "Are you working with Duke tonight?" Because he had a nice shirt on. And he said, "Yeah." I said, "How is he?" He said, "He's right over there at the takeout counter." And Duke lived upstairs and he was an ice cream junkie. He was standing at the takeout counter with a robe on it looked like he had since 1917. No socks on. Slippers. In this sophisticated restaurant in the middle of New York. And he turned around and saw me and he said, "Ahh, Mr. Appleyard" and gave me —

MR: How great.

PA: So that was fortunate working at The Colonial. Because everyone worked there, all the greats, and I can't even remember — Artie Shaw came. Goodman didn't come while I was there but oh, I can't remember, Erroll Garner, everybody.

MR: So you got to know them as personalities as well as musicians.

PA: Yeah.

MR: You know, how to behave, how to carry yourself?

PA: The Shearing thing. And you asked me did a guitar player help me? Toots was with him then — Toots Thielemans.

MR: Toots Thielemans, wow.

PA: And he was awfully kind to me because a vibraphone player, Johnny Ray, was leaving. And so he said, "What is your vote on George?" I said, "I don't know." Because prior to Johnny, a vibraphone player being with him — I'm just trying to think of his name — and George wasn't too generous in those days as regards to them playing. He would give them eight bars here and eight bars there you know, that kind of thing. So this guy came for my dinner this night, to my house for dinner, and he said, "Wait 'till I get to the gig tonight, I'm going to screw George." He said, "We're going to do 'Jordu,'" we always play it, to start off." And he said, "I'm going to take six choruses." And George is doing this you know. And he became the biggest percussionist in Hollywood, oh, and made a fortune.

MR: Not Emil Richards?

PA: Emil. Yeah, it was Emil.

MR: I'll be darned.

PA: But I hadn't seen him in all those years. Anyway, they put me in front of George and George said, "Can you do this?" And he went [scats frenetically]. I said, "No I can't do that." And Emil said, "That's too bad you can't do that because he won't hire a guy if he can't do that.

MR: Oh. Is that right?

PA: I didn't get it.

MR: It was like a mini-audition.

PA: You're the first person I told this story to I think. So I didn't get it, and I'm glad I didn't. Because it would take me away again, and I was concentrating on getting my own thing going eventually. I got a job with a man called Calvin Jackson. He was a brilliant pianist. He was the assistant musical director at MGM with Johnny Green. Brilliant musician. And he had this job, at a very nice sophisticated hotel in Toronto, and a weekly radio series and a weekly television series. And he hired me to be a guest on the television series. He liked me so much he asked me to join the quartet, which I did, and I went with him for about a year or so, and we played all the eastern seaboard — Chicago, Cleveland, we went to New York — and as a matter of fact we were opposite Ella and Oscar in New York at the Basin Street, which was a good experience. It was run by a very, very nice man called Ralph Watkins. And some years later, after I left Calvin, he hired me to play the Embers in New York, and then Morris Levy asked me to do 15 weeks a year with my own group at the Roundtable in New York. And I remember going back to see Ralph Watkins because he had Basin Street, and Pops, Louis Armstrong, was there. And he said, "Have you ever met Mr. Armstrong?" I said, "No, I'd love to meet him." "Oh," he said, "come on, we'll take you to the dressing room." So he took me to the dressing room and he opened the door, and here's Pops sitting there, he had just a pair of jockey shorts on, and he had a handkerchief on his head with each corner tied with a little knot, you know. And oh he was so nice to me and so encouraging. So that was a great experience, meeting him, and then of course at the Roundtable I worked opposite people like Andre Previn and all these major stars, and it was great. So I really did enjoy it. It was a great period in my life. And I still did a bit of traveling. And then one night I looked down and here's Benny Goodman in the audience. And so I naturally played all the Goodman stuff, you know. So I went down afterwards and said, "Good evening, Mr. Goodman, I hope you're having a nice time." Anyway, that was about it. And so we went back, and twelve years later, twelve years — now Benny had a reputation of having a bad memory. He called everybody Pops, even his wife. But I can tell you for a fact he didn't have a bad memory, and I'll explain that to you in a moment. Anyway, twelve years later he came back to Toronto with Derek Smith to play a concert for the CBC Big Band, Canadian

the critic for the Global Mail, a music critic, which is one of our big papers up there. And he played clarinet. So at the end of the concert he said, "Do you know Goodman?" I said, No I don't know him, he'd never remember me," I said, "He came to see me one night twelve years ago." He said, "Well let's go backstage and see if we can get a few words from him." I said, "Okay." So we go back and the dressing room door is open. And here's Benny sitting with a bottle of a Mickey, a black and white whiskey, a Scotch whiskey, having a little taste. So he stops and he looks at me and he says "Peter, how are you?" Twelve years later. I said, "Fine, Benny." He said, "What are you doing up here?" I said, "Well I live here and I've got a group in the theater, the hotel, and I'm doing concerts and I'm quite involved in studio work." I said, "What are you doing Benny?" He said, "Oh, the odd bar mitzvah." Then he said, "Naa, we're going in the Rainbow Room in October." I said, "Are you using vibes?" He said, "Why, would you like to come?" I said, "I'll come for union scale for you." He said, "Perfect." So about two weeks later the phone rings and it's Goodman. It was eight o'clock in the morning. I was just going off to do a television show with a country & western group, you know, a little percussionist. "Hello Peter, this is Benny. Benny Goodman." I said, "Oh Benny, how are you." He said, "Fine, we've got a concert in Hackensack with Bucky Pizzarelli, Milt Hinton, Bobby Rosengarden, Zoot Sims and Hank Jones and myself. Can you come?" I said, "When is it?" He says so-and-so. I said, "Yeah I can do it." That was the beginning of an eight year association.

MR: You drove from, was it Toronto you were in?

PA: I was in Toronto, yeah.

MR: From Toronto to Hackensack.

PA: He was the most encouraging and generous, to me, person that I've ever played for. Dick's very close. We have a different —

MR: Dick Hyman.

PA: closeness. Dick and Julia are so beautiful, people. But Benny encouraged me. I never got a ray, although I got one mini-ray once. It wasn't for playing. I stayed out for a day and a half. I had the time off, but the last time he saw me was leaving the Dorchester with Ava Gardner.

MR: And that got you the ray?

PA: I got it. I came back and he invited me to go to this party after the Royal Albert Hall you see. He said, "Come on over, come join us." I said, "Okay." And I was the only guy he used to invite. You know he didn't invite everybody in the band, just, it used to be me. I used to stay at his house in New York, in the penthouse, and he'd leave me there sleeping on the couch, right next to the office, with all the information, if I'd wanted to search

near it. I did what I was supposed to do. He'd take me up to Connecticut to the house there on the farm he had you know. And if he was going somewhere wherever he had to drive, he'd call me to drive him. And then afterwards we would go out to eat together you know. Anyway, we went to the Dorchester and I'm getting my fill of lobster and whatever, and this very familiar voice that I couldn't recognize for a moment, a lady, said, "Mr. Appleyard, we were at the concert tonight and we enjoyed you so much, would you like to join us for dinner?" I turned around and it was Ava Gardner. I thought about it for about ten seconds, and I said, "Sure, I'd love to." So we go to the table and she's with a major film producer, and so we started to have dinner together and I tried to get her to have a drink, she wasn't drinking, so I had a glass of wine I think. And then finally she said, "Let's step out of here and go to hear some jazz." So we went over to Ronnie Scott's and everybody knew her, she was a real jazz fan. Blossom Dearie was playing. She didn't like Blossom Dearie. But that guy, I never can remember his name, he was a drummer, he had a flute in the band and a cello.

MR: Oh, Chico Hamilton?

PA: Chico Hamilton, good. Yeah. Chico. And she knew Chico. So we hung out. So now it's about three in the morning, so she said, "Let's go back to my place." How am I going to handle this? What kind of a time am I going to have with Ava Gardner? The first thing she did, she walks in her apartment, or house it was, she put on Duke, and she's dancing to Duke. So now it's getting kind of late after about two hours, the maid comes down and joins us. And she said, "Oh, it's getting to be bedtime." And I said, "Ava, I have to go." And she said, "What?" It was probably the first time in her life any guy split after being with her all night. I said — and I was going through hell with my wife at home then, bad divorce. And I wanted to be straight. And I thought don't come on to Ava Gardner. She'll appreciate it all the more if you don't, I'm sure. And I'm sure she did appreciate it. So she said, "okay." And she went in the back and came back with some sugar tablets that she had, over-the counter things. She said, "On this tour with Benny," she said, "you're going to be tired a couple of times. Suck a couple of these to give you a little advantage." So she takes me outside and puts her arm around me and kisses me goodnight and gives me her card. She said, "Please call me when you come back to London." So I had to go up to Grimsby to visit someone, that lovely little girlfriend I had, and she was remarried and all that sort of stuff. I went to visit them. And so I came back, and I had been legitimately off you know. And so Muriel Zuckerman, who was Benny's secretary, was waiting for me in the lobby of the hotel. She said, "Where have you been for the last couple of days?" I said, "Well I've been up to Grimsby." "Oh," she said, "Mr. Goodman has been looking for you" and "Oh, here he is now." And he had a ray on. So the first

eyes, that would scare the hell out of the devil. Anyway he said, "Where have you been for the last 36 hours?" I said, "I went up to Grimsby to visit." He said, "Well the last time I saw you you were leaving with Ava Gardner." I said, "No. I was there a good part of the night," I said, "but I left and went on the train up to Grimsby to visit some relatives." He said, "Don't you ever leave this tour without me knowing exactly where you are." And walked away. So I turned to Muriel and I said, "Muriel, what was that all about? I'm 40 years old." She said, "He wanted to take you to the Ritz for dinner last night and you weren't there so he had to eat alone." But I really liked him. I could read him. And if I saw there was a mood there I wouldn't go anywhere near him. When he came to Toronto to play with the big band, I arranged the accommodation at this lovely hotel that I stayed at, and they gave him Pierre Trudeau's, our former Prime Minister's, penthouse suite, for nothing, for the week. And I had an old Silver Cloud Rolls Royce and I drove him to work every night in the Rolls you see. Then his daughter came, Benji, who was a lovely girl, and I picked them up and brought him from the airport and all that sort of stuff. Anyway a couple of weeks later we were playing in Ames, Iowa and he called me and said, "Are you busy" so-and-so. I said, "No, why?" He said, "Oh we've got this concert in Ames, Iowa. It's nothing" he said, "it's just a concert, but I'd like you to do it." So I got up to Ames, Iowa and it was one of these huge hockey rinks, about seven thousand people there, and he said, "Oh, it's nothing." The New York Philharmonic, conducted by Andre Kostelanetz.

MR: In Ames, Iowa.

PA: And Benny playing the Weber Clarinet Concerto, with seven thousand people waiting to hear "Honeysuckle Rose." It was incredible. So after we finished that night he said, "Let's go and get something to eat." So I said, "Okay." So we went off to get something to eat and I was having some apple pie. So he reached over and he said, "Let me try a piece of that." So he took — "oh that's good," he said, "oh by the way this is for you." And it was a jewelry box. I said, "What's this for, Benny?" He said, "That's for your hospitality in Toronto. Open it." I opened it and it was a pair of hand-sculpted nugget solid gold cufflinks, which I had appraised recently and the guy said, at Tiffany's, and he said, today, three or four thousand dollars. Ask him for a raise and he'd go insane. He'd go insane. We were going to Europe and I was in the apartment and he was paying me, I forget whether it was five hundred for the week or something. Of course this was in 1973 or '74. And we were to do five concerts you know. I said, "Benny, I can't go for that money." He said, "What do you mean you can't go for that money?" I said, "Well I'll make that money in the studio for a couple of days." He said, "You should be with me at all these major concert halls throughout Europe." I said, "But Benny, I need more

paying Zoot Sims." I said, "Good." It was a hundred dollars more. So then he said, "Let's go out to eat and celebrate." So he took me to, I think it's called the Century Club. It's on Fifth Avenue. And the list of members is like John B. Mellon, George D. Rockefeller, blah-blah, Benny Goodman. So we get there and oh it's incredible. He said, "Do you like it?" I said, "Oh, Benny, it's just incredible." It's all beautiful paneled you know. He said, "It's like a movie, isn't it?" I said, "Yeah." So the waiter came and said, "Mr. Goodman, what would you like tonight?" "Well," he said, "the roast beef, do you like roast beef, Peter?" I said, "Yeah, I do." He said, "Well we had that roast beef last time, prime rib. Do you have some?" He said, "Whoa, do we have some tonight, really, Black Angus." "Good. And by the way, that wine that we had the last time, what was it?" And this was '72 or '73. He said, "Yes, Mr. Goodman, it was a Chateau Latour. I think it was '60." He said, "bring a bottle of that." I looked at the menu, it was like five hundred dollars for the bottle. I felt like saying "Benny, I want that money."

MR: Right. I'll take that in my salary.

PA: Anyway, he took me downstairs when we were leaving, and I smoked a pipe in those days, and he stopped and said, "Just a minute." He said, "Give me some tobacco please. Dunhill, for Mr. Appleyard."

MR: Well he operated on his own terms, didn't he, to be generous or to be the typical Benny.

PA: Once he said to me, "Why do you take so many pictures?" I have a Leica you see, and I took a lot of pictures. I said, "Why, does it bother you, Benny?" He said, "If you ever take any of me and sell them, let me know." He wanted the money. So anyway, a couple of years ago I was in this second-hand shop this friend of mine used to run. And he had a tradepaper. "Oh," he said, "It was at an auction of musicians' artifacts in New York by Southeby's." He said, "This stuff of Benny Goodman's." "This hat," and he showed me a picture of it and I knew what it was because I recognized the hat, and a pair of shoe trees, and a photograph of Benny and his daughter sold for $1,750. I had taken the photograph.

MR: Is that right?

PA: So I looked to him and I said, "Benny, finally, I didn't get the money, somebody got $1,750 for the photographs. I had taken it in Copenhagen when we were there, we took it at Tivoli Gardens. Yeah. Bucky was with us quite a lot. Bucky was one of his favorites.

MR: Yeah. Why would a musician be his favorite? Were you able to figure that out?

PA: I really don't know. Bucky had a very nice personality and his wife is very lovely. I don't know. Because the one European tour that we did, Bucky was on guitar, he never gave him one solo the whole tour.

MR: Well why would he — conversely why would he fire somebody at a moment's notice? Do you know?

PA: Well sometimes people were taken to task. I never really saw him lose his temper, but Hank Jones, who is my favorite pianist, I mean he was so beautiful, incredible player, and Dick feels the same way, on that record, you know, he's on that record that I sent you. He was booked to be with us at some special function for the government and didn't show up. He told Benny that he'd been held up at the George Washington Bridge and couldn't make it. Benny called the New York Port Authority and found out there was no hold up on the bridge that day. So the next time he came to the states Benny took him to task and they started a fight on the stage. Not physically, but Hank, Hank was very genteel and very proper, and he was cursing at Benny. So he walked off the stage. Benny never used him again. Then on three occasions I booked Hank Jones and he didn't show up. The record I made over in Barbados was done with Bucky, Major Holly, Butch Miles, Rick Wilkins on tenor, and myself, without the piano. He was booked to play in Barbados. They even rented a German Steinway for him. And I called him two nights before we were to go on, because he was at Carnegie Hall with Ella. I said, "Hank, we've got a room at the airport on the night before the flight. We'd like you to be there with us so we can all leave early in the morning." "Oh, I'll be there," he said, "what kind of shoes do you want me to wear?" I said, "I don't care if you come in your bare feet but be there." "Oh, I'll be there." He didn't show up. So when we got to Barbados I had to make excuses for him. So I called him back again and I said, "What happened?" He said, "I forgot my passport." So then he said, "Well I'll be on the plane tomorrow." So we drove all the way across the island to pick him up, he didn't show up. So I called him again, I said, "Hank, what are you doing?" "Oh," he said, "I didn't like the attitude of the clerk."

MR: He said, what? I didn't follow you.

PA: He didn't like the airlines clerk, so he said.

MR: Oh dear.

PA: So then my friend said he would send a private plane to pick him up in Albany and fly him down to Kennedy, and he didn't show up. I get to Switzerland, I booked him in Switzerland to play with us. No Hank Jones. "Hank, what happened?" "Oh my car broke down on the way to the airport." "Oh, Hank," you know. Anyway, he finally showed up and strangely enough I'd booked him before in Toronto and he didn't show up again. He claimed he couldn't get out of here, out of New York, for the weather. And I got this guy Ian Barge to sub. So with the thing in Switzerland it so happened that Ian was working there and he said, "what happened? Didn't Hank Jones show up?" So now in Barbados I'm stuck. We had four days grace to get a pianist. I called John Bunch. And John said, "What happened, didn't Hank Jones show up?" "Yeah." I said, "How did you know." He said, "I knew about the gig." He said, "I can't come, I'm busy." And we had a snowstorm

But fortunately we had Bucky. The reason he was booked, the guy wanted him of course, to play, Jones, but he'd made a record with Ernestine Anderson and she was on the gig with us. So we had to accompany Ernestine without Hank. He was the greatest pianist. Well he was another Dick Hyman, of that caliber. Oscar Peterson caliber. But he had that reputation, which was so sad.

MR: I didn't know that. You know he lived like an hour south of here.

PA: He did, yeah.

MR: In Oneonta, New York.

PA: Yeah. He had a farm, didn't he?

MR: Yes he did.

PA: Yeah, because these people that are coming I hope, tomorrow night, from Chase Design, Dave Chase was a frustrated vibraphone player. And every year for about five years he would get me to hire six or five of the leading jazz players in America. I had every one of them playing in Skaneateles. He had a barn party in his barn. And Hank came and played. And so Dave said, "Well what do you want?" So he said, "I've just bought this farm, I'd like to have a horse." Well David had a lot of polo ponies, you know, he was a polo player. David Chase. He said, "Well I can give you a retired polo pony." He says "That'd be perfect." He never picked it up. But he was just one of a kind. We made a record when we were there, we made this record of, well it was a recording done by the Swiss government, you know, video and audio. And it was Hank Jones, Slam Stewart, Jerry Fuller, a wonderful drummer from Canada, and myself. And unfortunately the guy in Switzerland will not release it. I don't know why, after all these years. This is like 40 years ago. And this chap I've been in touch with is writing a book on Slam Stewart. And he knew about this date. And he wrote to this guy and said, "Could you tell me what the tunes were that you played" etc. And are you ever going to release that record. It was a wonderful record. Well how can you go wrong with Slam Stewart and Hank Jones?

MR: Before we run out of time I wanted to ask you a question I've been thinking about regarding the vibes. If I went to a set of vibes and pushed down the pedal and hit a note with the mallet, and then you went to the vibes and hit it, would it sound that much different?

PA: Yeah.

MR: Well why?

PA: It's like with the touch of a pianist. You can have Oscar Peterson sit at a Steinway and play a little bit, and then you'd have Dick Hyman do it, or Teddy Wilson or Billy Charlap, it'd all sound different. It's the touch. And it's the same with the mallet. Hampton used to play very softly but with very hard mallets. I use sort of a medium

know. I don't like to play too hard because then there's a limit as to how much volume you can get. But Hampton and I did a television show together. I had a television series I was the host of, and he came as a guest. And he played first of all, then we got together and we did "Seven Come Eleven" together. And I gave him my instrument and I had another instrument. He picked up my mallets. He started to play. That's Lionel Hampton. You could hear it right away. Red Norvo was another one. Red Norvo played so beautifully, very low with the mallets. He never looked at the keyboard. He could play like this. I used to impersonate these guys and I laughed and I said I used to wonder what he was looking for, and I think it was looking for a chick you know. Maybe tonight. Cal Tjader was another one that inspired me, told me I should go to New York, it was Cal. And he had a lovely sound. Johnny Ray, this other vibraphone player with Shearing, and Emil did. They all had their own particular sound. And it always amazed me that it varied. And it was the same with pianists. You know I could play a run, and Oscar could be right beside me and it would sound completely different. But it's the weight, the pressure I guess, and what he hears.

MR: Well that's a good answer, because you know you would think that well a wind instrument, it might be easier to get your own identifiable sound on a wind instrument I guess, there's more things that you can vary. But to your ears, the same is for the vibes.

PA: I can pretty well tell the type of instrument that they're playing. Through the years I've become so accustomed to that particular timbre of that instrument. Unfortunately I'm suffering with a hearing loss like we all do. Red could barely hear. You had to yell at him. Hamp too was suffering. But practicing the vibes every day, which I've done all my life, you're exposing yourself to this sound. My specialist told me that if you use an electric toothbrush every day it deteriorates the hearing.

MR: What was the racial attitude like in Canada? Was it any different toward African-American musicians, or was it good, bad or indifferent?

PA: When?

MR: I guess I'm thinking of when you first got there, or maybe in the 60s especially.

PA: Fortunately for me I grew up in a small English town, and there was no prejudice. The first black person I saw was a soldier that my father took in during the war. I revered them because of my knowledge of Teddy Wilson and Lionel Hampton and Charlie Christian, Louis Armstrong. The man that inspired me to play jazz first of all was Coleman Hawkins. And to me they were gods basically. I didn't know anything about prejudice. But there was a theory in New York at that time, in the 60s, that — I didn't live there per se, so I didn't experience it — but there was some kind of prejudice. Did they call it Uncle Tomism or something or other, or Tom Uncle?

PA: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. That you weren't authentic. That what you played couldn't be as good as a black musician.

PA: That's right. Yeah.

MR: Yeah, there was some of that, historically I guess.

PA: Yeah. I never experienced it. I've always had wonderful reception and encouragement from musicians. I traveled with an all-black rhythm section in the 50s, from Canada. A wonderful pianist called Wray Downes; Archie Alleyne, a drummer; and Bill Britto, a bass player. I used to stay in black hotels in Detroit and Chicago, to be with them. I didn't want to be apart and make them feel uncomfortable. But it was prejudiced, there was definite prejudice in those days. It wasn't easy for any of the black people, was it?

MR: No. But in Toronto, or where you lived, when the black musicians came up there was it, did they have issues?

PA: This man Calvin Jackson was Afro-American, and was immediately accepted for his talent. He was an incredible arranger. He did lovely music on the "American in Paris" I think, and some of these major MGM productions, with Johnny Green, and an incredible soloist. He studied at Juilliard with degrees and what-have-you, and consequently he had incredible technique, classical and jazz. He was more of a classically-orientated player, but still could play. The changes that he used to play were just so gorgeous. Yeah, and he was accepted. He had his own radio show. He was doing a television show weekly, one week with a big band then with a small group, and he had all the guests there. He had Ella there, and all kinds of people. Then he used to arrange for three or four of the major television shows. And so there was no prejudice there. There weren't that many black players in Canada, not in that time. Archie Alleyne was one prominent one who was a very good drummer. He's still around. Bill Britto travelled, and Wray Downes is teaching at Concordia University. He played a lot like Oscar. And with Oscar of course, he suffered with the prejudice thing. He told me once he went to get his haircut in Hamilton and the guy wouldn't cut his hair.

MR: Amazing. You mentioned doing some studio work over the years. Do you have any particular things that you remember from your studio work, either wonderful or ridiculous?

PA: I recorded for Maurice Jarre, who did Dr. Zhivago and all those films. I recorded for the greatest vocal writer that ever lived, Robert Farnon. I did his "Porgy & Bess." I did, for Oscar Peterson, "The Canadiana Suite," that was a highlight as a percussionist. I did Henry Mancini. I remember Mancini coming over to me and said, "No, I don't want it played — I want it done like this" and he picked up the mallets. And then I did — I

recorded with Anne Murray, Gordon Lightfoot, oh gosh, I can't remember them all. I recorded with Mel Torme — Mel Torment as Buddy Rich used to call him.

MR: Mel Torment?

PA: Yeah. I traveled with him too, to Japan, and played Michael's Pub with him for a month in New York. And we recorded in Tokyo. That was a great experience working with him. He wasn't that generous with the money but musically it was most gratifying. I enjoyed that.

MR: Maybe he learned that from Benny Goodman.

PA: And then, Whilst I was with Benny, in New York, Mr. Sinatra was going to have a show for two weeks at the Eros Theater with Ella Fitzgerald and the Basie Band, and a huge string section. And I went down to buy tickets and I couldn't get any, they were sold out. So I went over to Manny's Music Shop and I ran into Irv Cottler, his drummer.

MR: Who was it?

PA: Irv Cottler. In Manny's.

MR: Oh Irv Cottler, yeah.

PA: Yeah. A very good drummer, he was with Frank all those great years. And he said, "Peter, how are you?" I said, "Fine, Irv, how are you?" He said, "Good." He said, "We were talking about you last night." I said, "Who, me? Who?" He said, "Bill Miller," pianist, "and Frank and me." I said, "What are you talking about me for?" He said, "Well Frank wants to use vibes at the Eros, and Bill Miller said, "'Well why don't we get Peter Appleyard?'" So Frank said, "Peter Appleyard?" He said, "Yeah." He said, "He works with Benny." He said, "If he works with Benny, get him." I got the job without an audition.

MR: I guess you solved that problem of not being able to get tickets to the show.

PA: My wife came down and sat in the — no one else could sit in the audience, just one person, and she sat there to hear Frank rehearse with us.

MR: Oh, I see.

PA: At the end of the run — oh, on the second day he came up to me and he said, "Peter, I owe you an apology." I said, "What?" Frank Sinatra. I said, "What for?" He said, "There's not enough here to play." He said, "But sweetheart if you feel like playing behind me or Ella do it." At the end of the run he gives a party like it wouldn't quit on stage with him, the most beautiful wine and Italian food. He gave me a sterling silver jewelry box, engraved, "Peter, thanks F.S." He was a great guy. Generous, generous man.

MR: Great.

PA: And people have asked me "if you wanted to re-live two weeks of your life, or a week in music, which week will you choose?" And I think it would be those two weeks with him.

he and Ella with the Basie band. You're Ella, I mean you're Basie, and facing the other way, and I'm this close to you. And there's reams of music, reams of music, and Basie's looking going clink, you know. Frank goes "I get too hungry" and Basie goes bonk bonk, bonk bonk. All this music. So finally one night Frank sang "I get too hungry/for dinner at eight." And Basie goes [scats] and Sinatra turns around and said, "Bill, be careful, you might get a hernia." But oh, he was so great. And out of all the people I've ever, ever spoken to, and I've played and met the Queen Mother twice, no one gave me the sensation that I experienced with Frank Sinatra. He had the most beautiful face, to look at him. Beautiful teeth. And you think you've seen blue eyes? You've never seen blue eyes like those. But the speaking voice. It was like he was singing to me you know. He would come up occasionally and say, "How is everything going," you know. And then one night Benny came, and this is one to prove to you Benny had a good memory. We had dinner beforehand, Benny and I, and he came to the theater to hear Frank you see? And he also wrote a letter to the government on my behalf to get me permission to work with him for two weeks with Benny Goodman, see? I wish I had got a copy of that letter, it was really something. Anyway, Benny said to me, "Who's playing the piano for Frank?" I said, "It's Bill Miller." "Bill Miller, oh, yes," he said, "yes, yes, Bill. He did a couple of charts for the band." I said, "Oh, did he?" He said, "Say hello tonight, for me." I said, "Okay." So I get to work and I said, "Bill, I just had dinner with Benny and he told me that you wrote a couple of charts for the band." So Bill said, "No, I never wrote for the band, uh, my God" he said, "1935 when I was in high school, I remember now." Benny remembered all that way back.

MR: That's great.

PA: That's something, huh? Anyway and that night Benny was suffering with his slipped disc, he had a bad disc, as you know. And the next night Frank came up to me and he said, "Peter," he said, "Benny came last night and he didn't come back to say hello." I said, "no, Frank, he enjoyed the show so much but he was in such pain." And then he opened up to me, Frank did, about the big band era and what it was like and how tough it was for those band leaders. He said, "I really have great respect for them." He said, "because we'd be traveling on buses with broken seats and engines that kept breaking down, and they'd do 64 consecutive one-nighters." And then he got talking about watching Tommy [Dorsey] breathing. You know all that about the circular breathing. And tell me about how he used to swim a lot under water. It was really wonderful, because they asked you not to bother him if he came on stage. Nine times out of ten he would be in the wings digging Basie. He'd say "Shiny Stocking, Shiny Stocking." And then some nights they'd open up the band and Basie would open it, and Sinatra would be

one night he saw the music stands and they said CB on there, he came out and said, "Charlie Barnet!"

MR: Man, you've got a million stories. And I wish we could keep going. We're about to run out of film here. I enjoyed it so much and I'm looking forward to hearing you play tomorrow night.

PA: Oh thanks. Great pleasure to be here.

MR: And wish your wife a happy birthday for me.

PA: Oh thanks, that's nice of you. I took her out for dinner, and we had a lovely dinner and we saw four Italian singers, young boys, about a year ago, on the network that doesn't have commercials, what's that called?

MR: The PBS station? Okay.

PA: And they were great, they really were. And I really liked them too. They sang a lot of the old Italian songs but their harmony was beautiful. Presentation was marvelous. So we sent away, I did, for the video. It was a hundred bucks. It was the kind of thing you join the club and pay a hundred bucks or whatever it was. And he never came. So she got on the phone, it was a DVD, got on the phone, and, "oh yes but we had a mix-up" and went on and went on. Anyway, it arrived about two months ago, and I didn't say anything about it. So she keeps saying to me, "when are you going to give me the numbers on your credit card?" So anyway I had it as a surprise gift. Plus I gave her some American funds that I had. Because she's got a daughter that works for one of the major stores in America as an accountant. She's very good. And they've just moved her to Dallas. So I said, "here's some Dallas money for you."

MR: Good. Well thanks so much for your time.

PA: Well thank you. Lovely being here. Thanks for inviting me to play.